

Far-Right Speeches and Emotional Contagion in Parliament

Sequential and Multimodal Evidence from Germany

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The Question and the Existing Answer

Does far-right parliamentary success make democratic debate more negative?

Valentim & Widmann (2023)

- AfD entry into German state parliaments
- Established parties **do not** imitate far-right negativity
- Instead: **more positive** emotional language
- Interpretation: rhetorical distancing from a norm-breaking actor

But this is an average, entry-level, text-based result

- Aggregates across speeches and time
- Cannot reveal *immediate* reactions within debates
- Cannot capture *how* responses are delivered

What the Average Misses

The Sequential Dimension

Parliamentary debate is *ordered*: speeches respond to prior speeches within agenda items.

- What happens **immediately following** an AfD speech?
- Expected: anger ↑, positive language ↓; even if the aggregate is positive

The Multimodal Dimension

Speech is not only text: legislators communicate through pitch, head movement, and gestures.

- Do responses become **vocally and visually activated**?
- Are these channels coupled, or do they move independently?
- Expected: text follows text, pitch follows pitch, visuals follow visuals

Research Design and Case Selection

Research design



Case Selection

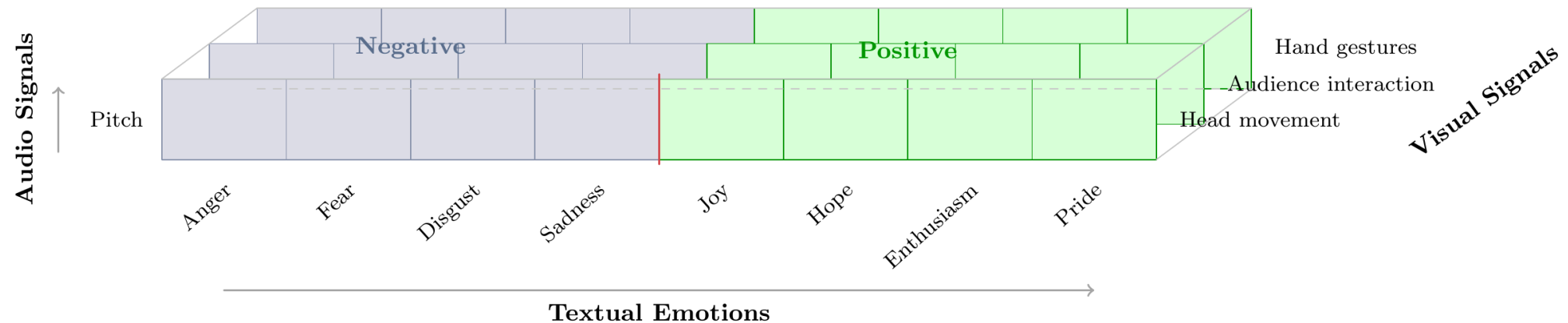
Parliament	Period	AfD from
Hesse	2013–2025	2019
Saxony-Anhalt	2021–2025	2021
Saxony	2019–2025	2019
Baden-Württemberg	2011–2025	2016
Bundestag	2017–2025	2017

49,662 speeches · 7,615 AfD speeches · ~15,000 hours of video

Measurement Framework

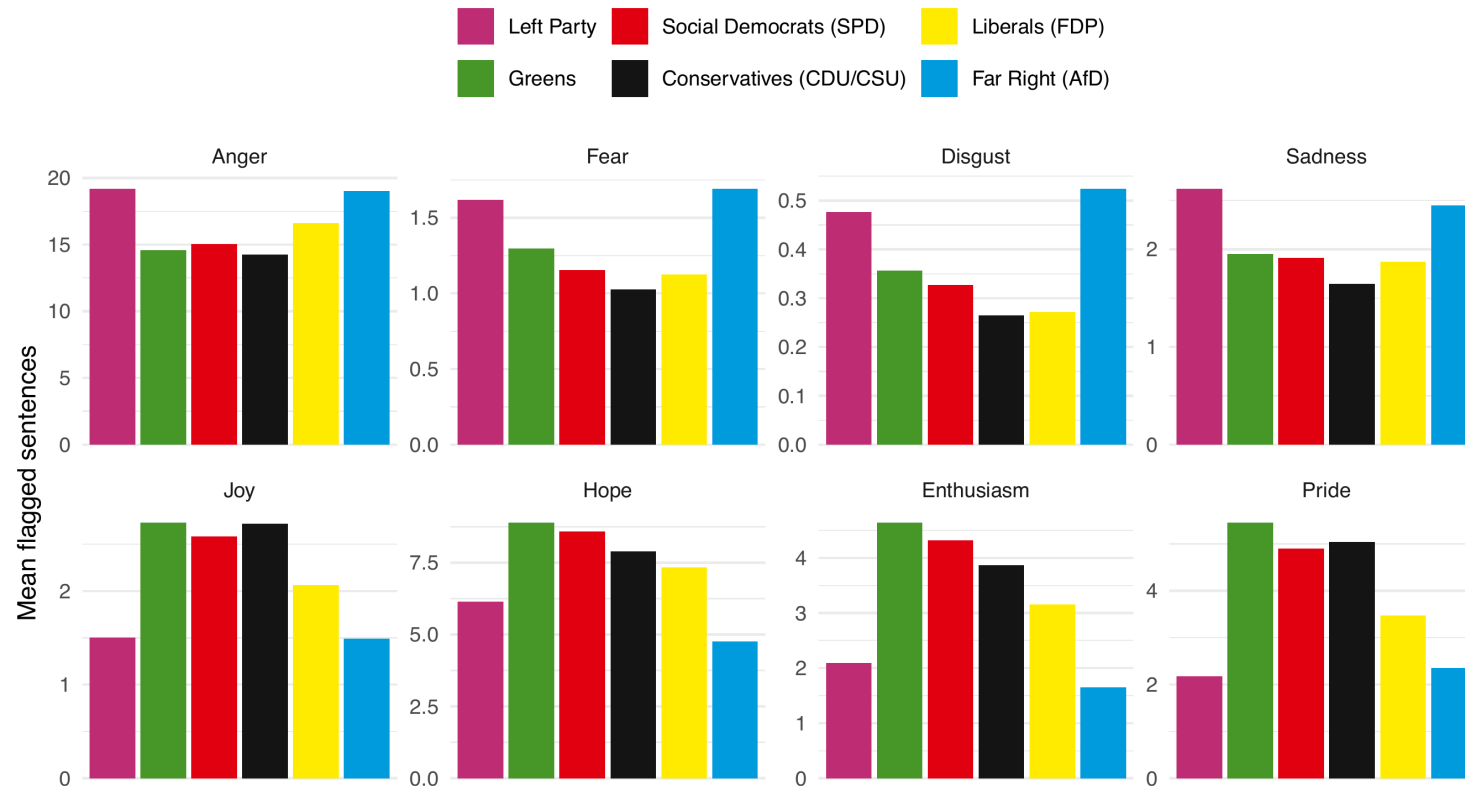
Three dimensions:

- **Text** (8 discrete emotions: anger, fear, disgust, sadness; joy, hope, enthusiasm, pride)
- **Audio** (pitch F0 mean)
- **Visual** (head movement, audience interaction, hand gestures)



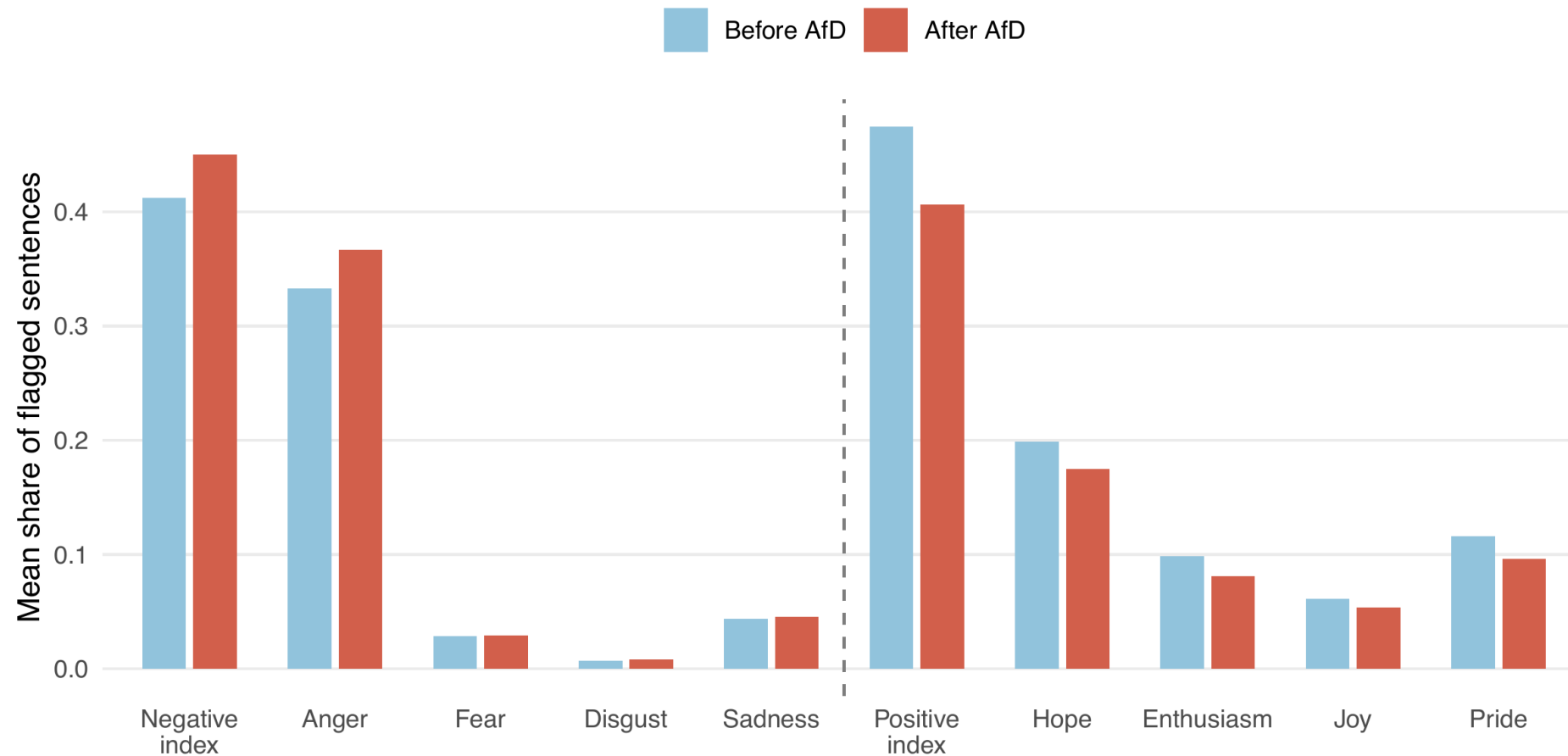
Result 1: Average Distancing

H1: Average semantic distancing: non-AfD parties respond to AfD presence with more positive language (replication)



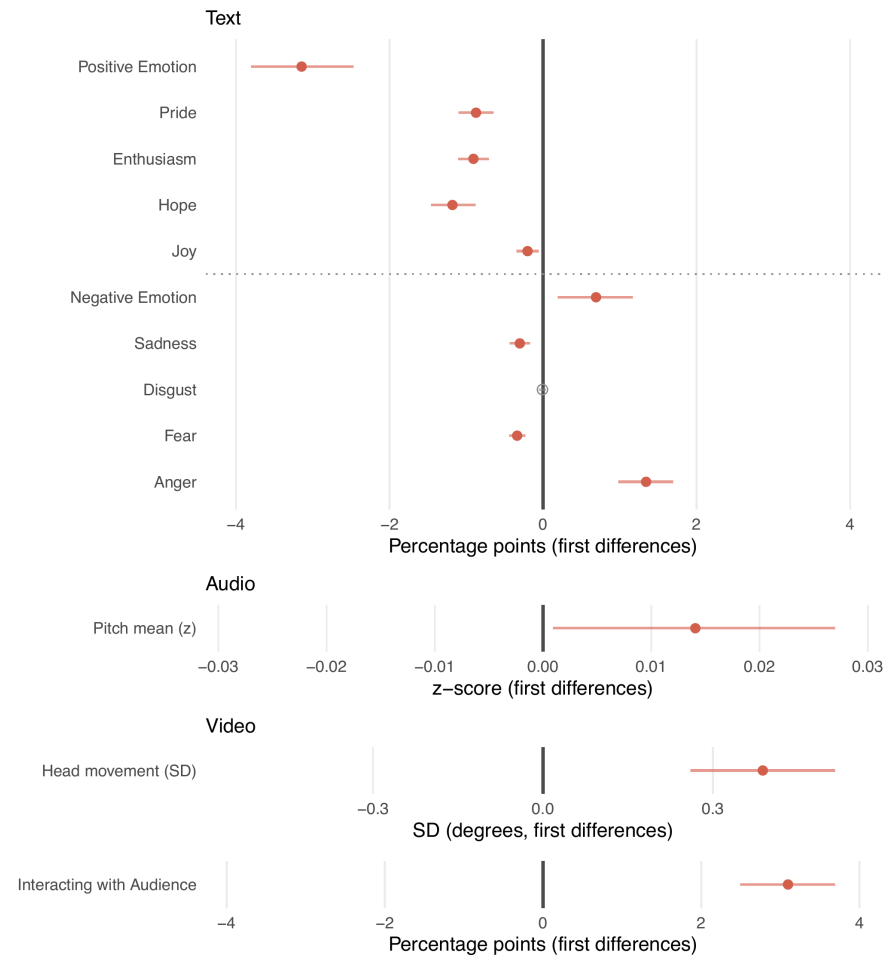
Result 2: Average vs. Sequential

H2: Sequential mirroring: speeches *after* AfD interventions contain more anger and less positive language (descriptive)



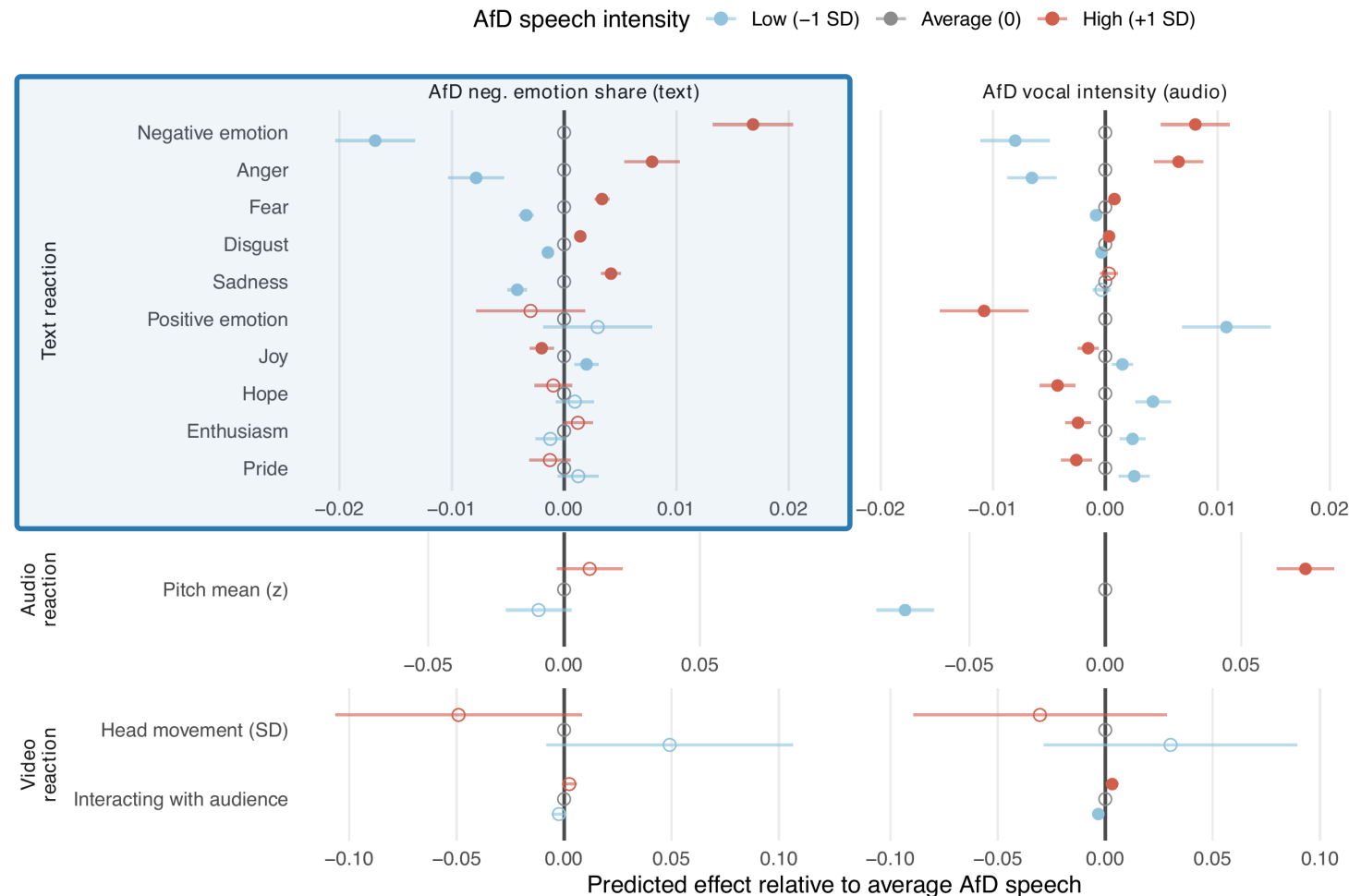
Result 2: Average vs. Sequential

H2: Sequential mirroring: speeches *after* AfD interventions contain more anger and less positive language (modelled)



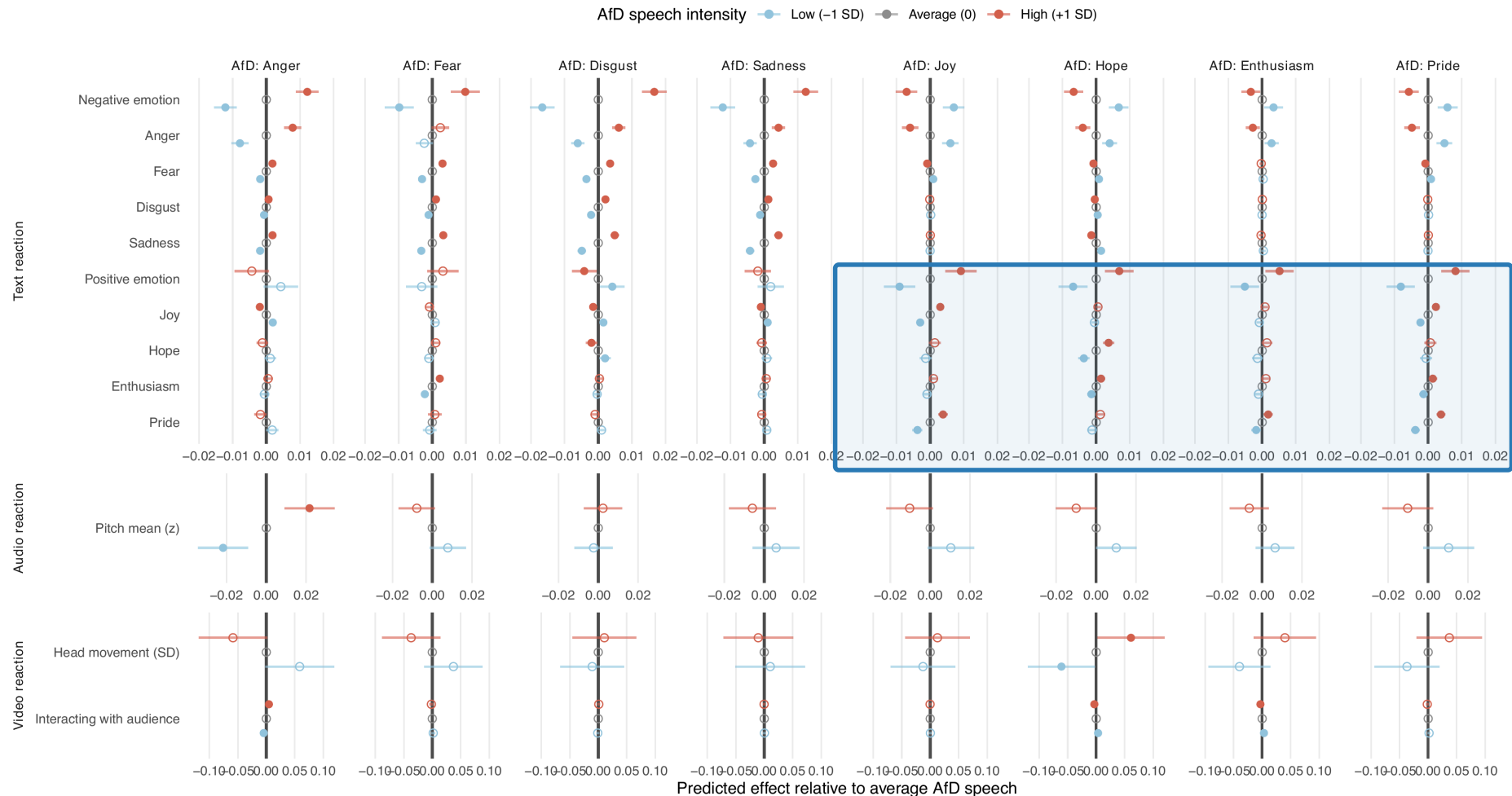
Result 3: Modality-Specific Transmission

H3: Vocally intense far right → pitch elevation (Audio); negative emotions far right → more anger in text (Text)



Result 4: Emotion-Specific Coupling

H4a Increased far right anger → pitch elevation; **H4b** Positive (negative) emotions transmit positive (negative) responses



Takeaways & Next Steps

Findings

- 1. Level-dependence:** Average distancing and sequential mirroring coexist; they operate at different levels of analysis
- 2. Modality-specificity:** Vocal activation follows vocal; text follows text; not a uniform contagion process
- 3. Emotion-specificity:** Anger is the discrete emotion most tightly coupled with pitch elevation
→ Far-right presence creates **repeated, localised episodes** of emotion- and modality-specific mirroring: locally intense, hard to detect in aggregate

Next Steps

- Expand corpus:** extend to all 16 German state parliaments and Bundestag
- Expand visual layer:** hand gestures not yet in models; next iteration incorporates the complete measurement matrix
- Causal identification:** DiD using the pre-AfD-entry period as control; shifts in the post-AfD window vs. baseline behaviour before AfD entered parliament

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